fortunate to have had the opportunity to play with him in the Lashings team. Sir Viv might be 58 now, but he is still as strong as a bull and oozes confidence. And he's still charging the bowlers. He's always got that swagger, and man, the women love him too.

One benefit he had playing for the West Indies in the 1970s and early 1980s was that he was never going to get bounced too often by opposition bowlers, because he had quickies like Andy Roberts, Michael Holding, Colin Croft, Joel Garner and Malcolm Marshall to back him up. The West Indies had one helluva bowling line-up, and team, back then.

Interestingly, their bowlers also helped their batsmen in a roundabout way. Viv told me how, during net practice, their bowlers used to run in and let their teammates have it. Apparently the bowlers never gave their own guys any rest, even in the nets. They would bomb them just as they would bomb the opposition out in the middle. Obviously this meant that when the West Indies batsmen went out to face the likes of England or Australia, it was a bit of a walk in the park.

And finally … no. 11, Shoaib Akhtar

Ja … a bit of a nutter, this guy. I've never ever felt safe facing him – even wearing a helmet – simply because his action makes it so difficult to pick up the ball. He doesn't show you the ball, so you can't read the seam, and he's got this long throwing action … well, I shouldn't say 'throwing action' … I'm sure Shoaib's never chucked a ball in his life … But anyways, let's just say it's a very difficult action with which to pick up the ball. And if that's not tough enough, add inconsistent bounce in the wicket and it becomes even trickier. We're talking a life or death situation here.

Fortunately, I haven't played against Shoaib in South Africa, with our bouncier wickets, often. He's had a lot of injuries, and controversies have also kept him out of the Pakistan team – but I have faced him a lot on the subcontinent. Even on those slower wickets, he's very effective swinging the new ball and reverse-swinging the old one. He has easily bowled the quickest balls I've ever faced. Through the air and off the wicket, he's even quicker than Brett Lee at his quickest. Add that awkward bowling action to the mix, and he's a tough guy to face.

Of course the word 'chucker' often appears in the same sentence as the name 'Shoaib Akhtar', but while he has been called a couple of times, nothing has really come of it. In my opinion, the authorities have been quite